

Which House Hack Fits You?

A decision guide. Answer honestly — not aspirationally. There's no prize for choosing the version that makes you miserable.



START HERE

Do you already own a home?

Yes → you may be closer than anyone still shopping. Skip to Section B.

No → start with Section A.

SECTION A — IF YOU'RE BUYING

Q1 How much sharing are you actually comfortable with?

A • I'd rather not share living space at all

→ **Small multifamily**, a **basement or in-law suite with a separate entrance**, or an **ADU / detached unit**.

Trade-off: higher purchase price, longer search, or conversion cost.

B • I'm fine sharing common space with the right people

→ **Room rentals** — from one housemate up to a full coliving house.

Trade-off: less privacy, but the fastest and cheapest start.

C • Not sure

→ Buy something with a **separate space** and rent it long-term. You can always add rooms later. You can't un-share a house you already bought.

Q2 How much capital do you have beyond the down payment?

A • Very little

→ **Rent what already exists, unfurnished**. No conversion, no furniture. Look for houses where the space is already usable.

B • Some — a few thousand

→ Small improvements are open to you: locks, doors, lighting, a mini-fridge, basic furniture. **Furnishing one space is possible**.

C • Meaningful reserves

→ Conversions and full furnishing are on the table. Still: **fund reserves first**, then improvements.

Q3 How much work do you want this to be?

A • As little as possible

→ **Small multifamily** or an **existing ADU**, long-term, unfurnished. Set it and mostly forget it.

B • A few hours a month is fine

→ **Basement unit** or **one to two bedrooms**, long or mid-term.

C • I want to operate something

→ **Room rentals at scale** (a full coliving house), or **furnished mid-term**. Highest income, real ongoing work.

Q4 Could you cover the full payment for three months with no rental income?

A • Yes, comfortably

→ You can stretch into a larger property where the income matters more.

B • Barely

→ Buy the property that **works if you rent one space**, with room to expand later. Make the extra income upside, not a requirement.

C • No

→ **Build reserves before you buy.** This is the most important line in this guide.

Q1 What space do you genuinely not use?

- ☐ A spare bedroom → lowest effort, start here
- ☐ A finished basement or in-law suite → check for a separate entrance and bathroom
- ☐ An unfinished basement → conversion project. Price it before committing
- ☐ A bonus room over the garage → hardest to separate, usually lowest return
- ☐ A garage or backyard → ADU territory. Highest cost, longest timeline, adds property value

Q2 Pick your level of effort**Level 1 • Rent what exists**

Lock, furniture, listing. Nearly free. **Start here.**

Level 2 • Small improvements

Door, lock, lighting, mini-fridge. Small money, real difference in what it rents for.

Level 3 • Real conversion

Bathroom, entrance, finishing. Real cost, real return, real timeline.

Most people jump to Level 3 in their heads and then do nothing. **Start at Level 1** and find out whether you like this before you spend anything.

Q3 Is everyone in your household on board?**No, or unsure**

→ This conversation comes before anything else. **A veto is a valid answer** — and honoring it makes people far more willing to actually consider it.

FURNISHED OR UNFURNISHED?**Go furnished if all three are true:**

- ☐ Near employers that bring people in on contract
- ☐ The space has genuine privacy — own entrance, own bath
- ☐ You have furnishing capital that isn't your reserves

Otherwise, start unfurnished. You can furnish later, once you know how the house actually operates.

LENGTH OF STAY

	INCOME	WORK	TURNOVER
Long-term	Lowest	Lowest	Rare
Mid-term	Higher	Moderate	A few times a year

Short-term

Highest

Highest — it's hospitality

Constant

First house hack? Long-term, unless you have a specific reason otherwise. Your first year has enough going on.

YOUR ANSWER

Model

Furnished / unfurnished

Length of stay

First step this week

THE HONEST TEST

The best house hack is the one you'll actually stick with.

A modest one you run for five years beats an ambitious one you abandon in eight months. The money difference between models is smaller than the lifestyle difference.

Every door is an opportunity.

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